
THE OFFICE OF UNFUNDED SPEECH

*Ilyas AS, Serial 0124, and the Transmission That Left No Book, No Patron, and
No Grave*

SAPIENT MONOGRAPH

A transmission read where its carrier is not

1000 SAPIENTS · BAND E1 · LEV

ABSTRACT. Elijah AS, Ilyas AS in the Quranic register, holds seat 0124 of the 1000 Sapients register at the Carried grade, where the aperture sits at the upstream: a transmission survives and is datable, and its carrier is not. This monograph follows the transmission. It argues that what crossed twenty-eight centuries was not a doctrine and not a book but an office, and that the office is defined by three absences the record is unusually clear about. No oracle collection stands under his name, in a kingdom that produced two within a century of his death. No patron paid him, in a court economy where prophecy was salaried from Mari to Samaria. No grave holds him, in a religious culture that anchored memory to tombs. The argument is that these are not gaps in the evidence but the mechanism of the transmission, and that the mechanism is legible precisely because the Deuteronomistic redactors who preserved the cycle were southern scribes with an interest in the northern kingdom's failure and preserved several things against that interest anyway. The reading closes on the deletion test, which returns a small answer at the level of events and a large one at the level of form.

KEYWORDS *Omride Israel · Deuteronomistic History · Baal Cycle · Tyrian treaty marriage · nahalah and royal expropriation · prophetic guild economics · Carmel · Horeb theophany · Malachi forerunner · testimony against interest*

I. SEAT AND GRADE

Ilyas AS, Elijah AS in the Hebrew register, אֵלִיָּאֵהוּ *Ēliyyāhū*, "my God is Yahu," a name that is itself the thesis of the career it belongs to. Serial 0124. Band EI, before 800 BCE. Zone LEV. Dated traditionally to c. 865 BCE by the reign of Ahab 0129, whose absolute date is fixed from outside the Hebrew corpus by the Kurkh Monolith of Shalmaneser III at the battle of Qarqar in 853 BCE [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1]. Existence-grade Carried, tag SG, attested c. 620 BCE through the Deuteronomistic History at Tier 3. The seat is funded within Zone LEV by the supersession of Hiram I, whose two clauses were already carried at Sulayman AS 0123 and Melqart 0121, and the substitution is the register's own mechanism rather than an exception to it.

The Carried grade is not a downgrade and it is not a hedge. It is a statement about where the open question sits. For a Somatic seat the aperture sits at biography: the body is attested and what remains uncertain is the life. For a Carried seat it sits one level upstream: something demonstrably crossed centuries and language boundaries, the crossing is datable, and the carrier is not. That is exactly the evidentiary shape here, and the register already applies it to a structurally identical case. Yunus AS 0137 is seated Carried, SG, attested c. 600 BCE through the Book of Jonah at Tier 3: a prophet who survives only as the subject of third-person narrative with no oracle collection in his own voice. Ilyas AS is that case again, one century earlier and with a far heavier downstream. The grade is assigned by precedent, not by preference.

What the record does not contain should be stated at the top rather than discovered halfway. No contemporary inscription names him. This is not a general condition of the period: his king is named on an Assyrian monolith, his king's father is named on the Mesha Stele and in five Assyrian records that call the state Bit-Humri for a century after the dynasty fell, and the Moabite king who revolted against his house left a stele in his own voice. The ninth-century Levant is one of the better-attested centuries in the whole band. The register holds the king, the king's father, the king's overlord, the neighbouring king who wrote about the war, and the god the prophet fought. It does not hold a single object bearing his name. That asymmetry is the first datum of the monograph and not an embarrassment to be managed: it is precisely what a Carried seat looks like when the surrounding milieu is well lit.

The thesis. Ilyas AS holds his seat on a transmission whose distinguishing property is a triple absence. He leaves no scroll, in a prophetic culture that within a century of his death produced Amos and Hosea in his own kingdom, both of whom left collections. He leaves no patron, in a Near Eastern institutional landscape where prophecy was overwhelmingly a salaried palace function. He leaves no grave, in a memorial culture that built shrines on tombs and where the location of the patriarchal burial cave was itself a property claim. This monograph argues that the three absences are one mechanism, that the mechanism is an office rather than a doctrine, and that the office is the thing that crossed. The office is unfunded, unappointed, non-hereditary public arraignment of power on a stated criterion, transmitted to a successor by a garment rather than to a library by a scribe. Every later Hebrew prophet who confronts a king inherits its posture; the eschatological forerunner slot of Malachi is built out of it; and the Gospel opening has no grammar without that slot.

The warrant is stated at its honest grade throughout. That such a transmission existed and is datable is documented. That its earliest carrier bore this name is the tradition's claim, carried at Tier 3, uncorroborated by any Tier 1 or Tier 2 witness, and it stays there. Nothing in what follows upgrades it.

II. MILIEU

2.1 THE STATE AT ITS MAXIMUM

The Omride kingdom into which the tradition places him was the most internationally successful regime northern Israel ever ran, and this needs saying first because the corpus that preserves Ilyas AS was written by people committed to the opposite verdict.

Omri 0128 bought the hill of Samaria and built a capital on it, and the purchase is worth holding: the text that records it (1 Kings 16:24) records a legal acquisition of land by a king, which is the exact transaction that will fail three chapters later. Five Assyrian records name the state Bit-Humri, the House of Omri, and continue naming it so for over a century after the dynasty was destroyed, which is the strongest external index of how the founder registered on the imperial chancelleries [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1]. The Mesha Stele, c. 840 BCE, is Moab's own account and names Omri as the oppressor who humbled Moab for forty years [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1, seated at Mesha 0132]. The Kurkh Monolith of Shalmaneser III lists the coalition that met Assyria at Qarqar in 853 BCE and credits Ahab the Israelite with two thousand chariots and ten thousand infantry, the largest chariot contingent in the alliance and larger than Damascus [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1, seated at Shalmaneser III 0130]. Samaria's excavated acropolis produced the ivory inlays that give the Hebrew phrase "the ivory house" a material referent [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1]. Jezreel's fortified enclosure has been excavated and dated to the same dynasty [CONSENSUS; Tier 1].

This is a state with a standing armoured force, two capitals, a Phoenician trade partnership, a tributary to its east, and a recognised name in Assyrian records. The Hebrew corpus gives its kings a religious verdict. Assyria gives them a chariot count. Both are evidence and neither cancels the other, and the monograph keeps them visibly apart.

2.2 THE CORRIDOR: HOW BAAL ARRIVED IN SAMARIA

Traditions do not diffuse by ambient similarity. They are carried along physical routes with datable strata, and where a monograph cannot name the route it has skipped the only part an archive can verify.

The route here is short, documented, and matrimonial. Jezebel is the daughter of Ethbaal, king of the Sidonians (1 Kings 16:31), a Tyrian dynast whose name Josephus, quoting Menander of Ephesus, renders Ithobalos and identifies as a priest of Astarte who took the throne by coup [DISPUTED; Tier 4]. The marriage is a treaty instrument of a kind the Late Bronze and Iron Age Levant used constantly, and the register already carries its precedent one century earlier: Sulayman AS 0123 is seated on "the Tyre alliance and the Red Sea trade," and Hiram I, the seat this one supersedes, was Tyre's half of it. The economics are unambiguous. Tyre is an island city with a maritime economy, timber and craft exports, and a chronic deficit in grain and oil. The Jezreel and coastal plains are among the best cereal ground in the southern Levant. Israel supplies food and a land corridor; Tyre supplies craft, capital, and access to the Mediterranean network that Melqart 0121 carries all the way to Carthage and Gades. A treaty marriage is how that relationship is secured, and a royal wife brings her household cult with her because that is what a treaty marriage is.

So the Baal who appears in Samaria is not a generic Canaanite survival. He arrives by a named mechanism, on a named route, in a named generation, as the cultic term of a commercial treaty. That is the corridor, and the whole cycle is unintelligible without it. The prophet is not fighting a folk religion. He is attacking the religious clause of the kingdom's most valuable foreign contract.

2.3 THE RIVAL THEOLOGY, STATED PRECISELY

The register seats Baal 0082 at the Cultic grade on the Ugaritic Baal Cycle, written down by Ilimilku 0079 at Ugarit c. 1400 BCE and glossed in the roster's own words as the antagonist against whom Israelite monotheism defined itself in polemic. The technical content of that cult is what the entire Elijah AS cycle turns on, and skipping it makes the drought look like a generic disaster instead of the targeted strike it is.

In the Ugaritic corpus Baal Haddu is the storm. His voice is thunder, his weapons are the lightning-shaft and the mace, his palace is completed only when a window is opened in it so that he can thunder through, and his defeat by Mot is followed directly by the failure of the rains and the withering of the furrows, while his return is announced by the heavens raining oil and the wadis running with honey [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1, KTU 1.1 to 1.6]. Rain is not one of his attributes among others. Rain is his professional competence and the index of whether he is alive or swallowed.

Now read 1 Kings 17:1. A man appears before the king and swears that there will be no dew and no rain except at his word. In a court whose queen has installed the rain-god as a treaty deity, a multi-year drought is not a general misfortune. It is a public failure by a named specialist in his own single area of competence, and the announcement claims the withholding for someone else. Everything that follows, three years of it, is a demonstration conducted inside the opposition's domain and on the opposition's advertised strength.

There is a further precision worth stating because it cuts against a lazy reading. The Baal Cycle already contains a drought sequence and already has an explanation for it: Baal is not incompetent, he is swallowed by Mot and will return. So the Tyrian side of the court had a fully articulated theological account of a long drought available, and the contest was never over whether drought could occur. It was over whose

withholding it was and whose word ended it. That is a jurisdiction dispute, not an argument from anomaly, and the difference matters for how the ordeal at Carmel is designed.

2.4 LAND, AND THE TWO REGIMES THAT COLLIDE

The second half of the milieu is not cult but tenure, and the corpus is explicit about it.

Israelite land law as the Torah preserves it holds the *naḥalah*, the patrimonial allotment, to be inalienable in principle: the land is not sold in perpetuity because it is not the holder's to sell (Lev 25:23), and tribal allotments are barred from transferring between tribes (Num 36:7) [Tier 3, and the dating of the legal codes relative to the ninth century is itself contested; CONSENSUS on the principle's antiquity, DISPUTED on its written form at this date]. Against that stands the Canaanite and broadly Near Eastern royal regime, in which the crown accumulates estates, grants them to officers, and exercises effective eminent domain, a system the Ugaritic and Alalakh land grants document in detail [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1].

Ahab straddles both. His father bought a hill and paid for it. He himself opens the Naboth transaction with an entirely lawful offer, a better vineyard in exchange or the silver value in cash (1 Kings 21:2), and when refused he goes home and sulks rather than seizing. The text preserves a king who accepts, at first, that there is something he cannot buy. That preserved detail is what makes the episode a collision of regimes rather than a story about a bad king, and it is the reason the case became the permanent template for prophetic critique of expropriation.

2.5 PROPHECY AS A SALARIED PROFESSION

The last element of the milieu is the one modern readers most reliably miss, and the whole actuation depends on it. In the ninth-century Near East, prophecy was overwhelmingly an institution with a payroll.

The Mari archive, five centuries earlier and seated in the register at Zimri-Lim 0060, documents the *āpilum* and the *muḥḥûm* delivering divine messages to the palace, with their reports filed, their credentials checked by a lock of hair and a hem of garment sent with the tablet, and their maintenance a palace expense [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1]. The system is administrative. In the Hebrew corpus's own account of this reign, 1 Kings 18:19 puts four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal and four hundred of Asherah at Jezebel's table, and the phrase is a payroll term, not a metaphor. 1 Kings 22 stages four hundred court prophets under Zedekiah ben Chenaanah performing with iron horns and returning the answer the king commissioned, against one dissenting prophet whom the king says he hates because he never prophesies good. The scene is a satire of an institution the audience recognised.

That is the baseline. Prophecy in this world is a court function, paid, credentialed, and answerable to the payer, and the products behave accordingly. Whatever else the Elijah AS material is, it is the record of something outside that arrangement, and Movement V will argue that being outside it is not a biographical accident but the instrument itself.

III. FORMATION

3.1 WHAT THE RECORD GIVES, WHICH IS ALMOST NOTHING

This is the movement where a Somatic monograph earns its length, and here it collapses. The collapse is stated rather than padded, and then the little that survives is worked hard.

"Elijah the Tishbite, of the settlers of Gilead" (1 Kings 17:1). That is the entire biographical apparatus the corpus supplies at his introduction, and two of its three elements are uncertain. Tishbe is unlocated; the Hebrew *mittōšabê* has been read both as "of the inhabitants" and as a corrupted gentilic, and the ancient versions already diverge [DISPUTED; Tier 3]. Gilead is secure as a region: Transjordan, east of the river, pastoral and highland, structurally peripheral to the Samaritan core where he acts.

No father is named. This is not the norm and the exception is worth registering. Hebrew prophetic superscriptions characteristically give a patronymic: Isaiah AS ben Amoz, Hosea ben Beerī, Jeremiah AS ben Hilkiah, Ezekiel AS ben Buzi, Zechariah ben Berechiah. Ilyas AS gets a gentilic and no lineage. Two readings are live and neither can be closed on present evidence. It may be redactional loss, an introduction abraded in transmission. Or it may be a deliberate mark on a man who holds no lineage claim, which would be consistent with everything else about the figure, since a prophet with no father named is also a prophet with no priestly house, no tribal patrimony, and nothing to inherit or bequeath. What would decide it is a variant tradition preserving a patronymic, and none survives in the Masoretic text, the Septuagint, or Josephus. State the fork and leave it open.

No teacher is named, and no guild is claimed. This matters because the guild demonstrably exists in his lifetime: the bene ha-nevi'im, the sons of the prophets, appear as an organised body with communities at Bethel, Jericho, and Gilgal, with a common table and a building programme (2 Kings 2:3, 2:5, 4:38, 6:1), and Obadiah the palace steward hides a hundred of them in caves during the persecution (1 Kings 18:4). So the institution is there, in his own generation, and he is never placed inside it. He appoints into it rather than emerging from it (1 Kings 19:16). Whatever formed him, the record's own account is that it was not the available professional structure.

3.2 WHAT THE RECORD GIVES INSTEAD, WHICH IS A TEMPLATE

Where a teacher should stand, the corpus supplies a typology, and it does so openly enough to be read.

The Horeb sequence is constructed out of Musa AS point for point. Forty days and forty nights in the wilderness, matching Exodus 34:28 and Deuteronomy 9:9. Arrival at Horeb, the same mountain under the same name the Deuteronomic tradition uses. Standing in a cleft or cave while the presence passes, against Exodus 33:22 where Musa AS is placed in the cleft of the rock and covered while the glory passes. Covering the face, against Exodus 3:6. A commission received at the mountain and carried back down. The correspondence is dense, systematic, and in the same direction throughout, and the scholarly reading that the redactors are constructing a second Musa AS is settled [CONSENSUS; Tier 3].

The honest typing is the whole point of this movement. That correspondence tells us with high confidence how the tradition formed the figure. It tells us nothing about how the man was formed, and no source does. Naming that cost is the discipline: in a Somatic monograph this movement would carry teachers, texts, a workshop, a chair, a language of instruction, and the first thing rejected. Here it carries a redactional reading and one geographical fact, and the reduction is a finding about the record, not a gap to be filled with plausible invention.

3.3 THE ONE DATUM THAT IS NOT TYPOLOGY, AND ITS LATER CONFIRMATION

Something does survive that is not template, and it is a trajectory rather than a biography: he comes from the periphery into the core. Transjordanian Gilead to Samarian court, and then across the border into Phoenician Zarephath.

That trajectory recurs, and its clearest later occupant states its economics out loud. Amos, a century after, comes from Tekoa in the southern hills to the royal sanctuary at Bethel in the north, and the priest Amaziah expels him with a sentence that is unmistakably about money: go back to Judah, eat bread there, and prophesy there (Amos 7:12). The accusation is that he is a jobbing prophet working a foreign market. The answer is a denial of both salary and guild in one breath: I was no prophet, nor a prophet's son, I was a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs (Amos 7:14). "Prophet's son" is *ben-nābī*, the guild term. Amos is denying membership in the bene ha-nevi'im and denying that he eats bread for oracles, and he is doing it in the northern kingdom, at the royal sanctuary, roughly four generations after Ilyas AS.

That is the office described from the inside by its clearest later holder, and it is the strongest single indication that what Ilyas AS opened was a structural position rather than a personal style. The dependency runs the right way and the warrant is honest: Amos is a documented collection in his own voice at Tier 3 with a secure eighth-century setting, and his self-description matches the Elijah AS material's structure exactly. That is corroboration of the office. It is not evidence of the man, and it is not offered as such.

IV. THE ACTUATION

The load-bearing movement. Four acts, each read as a mechanism rather than as a wonder, and the domain guard binding throughout: this instrument reads transmission architecture and conduct. It issues no verdict on whether any event occurred, and the question of what stood behind the theophany routes out of band and stays there permanently.

4.1 THE DROUGHT: A STRIKE AIMED AT A COMPETENCE, NOT AT A BELIEF

1 Kings 17:1 is four clauses long and every one of them is doing work. He stands before the king, unannounced and uninvited. He swears by the living God of Israel, *hay-YHWH*, an oath formula that stakes the speaker's standing on the outcome. He names a duration open-endedly, these years. And he attaches the ending of it to a condition, "except by my word."

The target is Section 2.3's specialist. A drought announced in these terms, in this court, in this generation, is a public test of a rain-god's competence in his single advertised domain, conducted in the domain rather than argued about from outside it. And because the Baal Cycle already carried an account of drought, the claim being contested is not whether the rains can fail. It is jurisdiction: whose withholding this is, and whose word ends it. That framing is what makes the eventual Carmel procedure necessary. A jurisdiction dispute cannot be settled by the drought itself, since both sides can narrate it. It requires an adjudication.

One external trace is worth handling carefully because it is routinely either inflated or ignored. Josephus, citing Menander of Ephesus on the Tyrian records, reports a drought in the reign of Ithobalos of Tyre lasting a year, ended when the king made supplication (Ant. 8.13.2) [DISPUTED; Tier 4]. This is a first-century Judean author quoting a Hellenistic-era epitomiser of Tyrian annals, three removes from any archive, and it is not independent verification of anything in 1 Kings. What it is, and the distinction is worth keeping, is a notice of a drought in the same reign-window preserved on the other side of the treaty, in a source with no interest in the Israelite prophet and no knowledge of him. It corroborates a climatic event and nothing else. It is recorded here at that weight and it carries no further load.

4.2 CARMEL: THE DESIGN IS THE FINDING

1 Kings 18 is normally read for its outcome. The register reads it for its procedure, because the procedure is the part that transmits.

The design has four properties and each is a deliberate choice. The materials are equalised: two bulls, two altars, wood, no fire applied by either party. The order of attempt is conceded to the opposition, and conceded explicitly, "choose one bull for yourselves and prepare it first, for you are many." The criterion is announced in advance, stated once, and is single: the god who answers by fire. And the venue is public and includes the king, so neither side can adjudicate privately afterwards.

That is an ordeal with a pre-declared outcome condition, procedural symmetry, and the advantage of first attempt given away. Whatever a reader holds about what happened on the mountain, the form is the finding, and the form is what later readers inherited: a cult question submitted to a stated test rather than to royal decision, priestly assertion, or the count of adherents. The register's own operating law zeroes consensus as warrant in both directions, and the Carmel design is the earliest scene in the Hebrew corpus that does the same thing on its own initiative, with the numerical asymmetry named out loud as a reason to concede advantage rather than as an argument.

The site is not incidental either. Carmel is the ridge running to the sea at the boundary between Israelite territory and the Phoenician coastal zone, a frontier high place with a long cultic history; a later Greek notice has Vespasian sacrificing at an altar on Carmel with no temple and no image, which indicates an open-air cult of considerable antiquity there [DOCUMENTED; Tier 2, Tacitus, Hist. 2.78]. A contest staged on Carmel is a jurisdiction claim over a border sanctuary, which is the geographical form of the same jurisdiction dispute the drought opened.

And the episode does not end with the fire. It ends at the Kishon with the slaughter of the defeated prophets (1 Kings 18:40). A monograph that narrates the ordeal and omits the killing has silently taken the tradition's side, which is the failure this register exists to prevent. The killing is recorded here as the text records it, and

the opposition's case, which is a real case, is taken up at its strongest in Movement VI rather than defused in passing.

4.3 NABOTH: THE ACTUATION WITH THE LONGEST DOWNSTREAM

1 Kings 21 is the episode that matters most for what came after, and its mechanism is more specific than its reputation.

The sequence is preserved in legal detail. The king makes a lawful offer, purchase or exchange at the owner's choice. The owner refuses on patrimonial grounds, in the technical vocabulary: the God of my fathers forbid that I give the *naḥalah* of my fathers to you. The king withdraws and does nothing. The queen then executes the seizure through the courts, and the text preserves every step of the instrument: letters written in the king's name and sealed with his seal, sent to the elders and nobles who lived in Naboth's own city; a fast proclaimed, which frames the proceeding as a response to some communal offence; Naboth seated at the head of the people, which is the position of an honoured man and makes the subsequent charge a public reversal; two men of no worth seated opposite as witnesses, meeting the two-witness requirement in form; the charge of cursing God and the king, which is capital; execution by stoning outside the city; and the elders and nobles complying and reporting back in writing.

The mechanism preserved is therefore not lawless seizure by a tyrant. It is judicial murder conducted through correct legal form by the local judicial class, on written instruction, with the paperwork returned. The crown supplies the seal; the city's own elders supply the verdict.

And the prophet's intervention is not a lament and not a later oracle. It is an arraignment delivered in person, at the scene, to the reigning king, by a man holding no office, with a sentence attached and no immunity claimed. The king's first words are the recognition that this is what has happened: have you found me, my enemy.

The actuation, stated as mechanism rather than as praise: this is the earliest text in the Hebrew corpus in which an unappointed individual confronts a reigning monarch over a property crime against a commoner, and in which the confrontation is preserved as legitimate rather than as sedition. Everything downstream in the prophetic critique of expropriation runs through it. Amos on selling the needy for a pair of sandals and on those who trample the head of the poor (Amos 2:6-7). Isaiah AS on those who join house to house and field to field until there is no room (Isa 5:8). Micah on those who covet fields and seize them, and houses and take them away, oppressing a man and his house, a man and his patrimony (Mic 2:2), which uses the same term Naboth used. The template is set in one scene and reused for three centuries.

4.4 HOREB: THE THEOLOGICAL MOVE WITH THE LONGEST REACH

1 Kings 19:11-12 is short and structurally exact. A great wind splitting mountains and breaking rocks, and the formula: not in the wind. An earthquake, and not in the earthquake. A fire, and not in the fire. Then *qōl demāmāh daqqāh*.

The phrase resists translation because it is built to. *Qōl* is voice or sound. *Demāmāh* is silence or stillness. *Daqqāh* is thin, fine, beaten-out, the adjective used of finely ground powder. The construction pairs sound with silence and then attenuates it, and every English rendering has to sacrifice something: "a still small voice" keeps the sound and loses the silence, "a sound of sheer silence" keeps the paradox and loses the thinness, "a thin whisper of quiet" keeps the attenuation and loses the register of *qōl* as an oracular voice.

The structural point is the one that carries. Wind, earthquake, and fire are the storm-god's entire signature vocabulary, and the passage negates them one at a time in sequence. At Carmel the answer came as fire, which is to win inside the opponent's idiom on the opponent's terms. At Horeb the idiom itself is set aside. That is a different and larger move: it decouples divine presence from meteorological display altogether, in a text produced inside a culture whose dominant regional theology was precisely a theology of meteorological display.

Honest typing, and it matters here because the reading is attractive enough to overclaim. That the sequence negates storm-theophany elements is on the face of the text and is not in dispute. That the negation is a deliberate anti-Baal polemic by the redactor is a scholarly judgment held by most who work on the passage [CONSENSUS; Tier 3], with dissent that reads it as an internal critique of the Sinai tradition rather than an external polemic [DISPUTED; Tier 3]. Either reading supports the structural claim; the polemical reading is not load-bearing for it.

Note also what the passage does with the prophet himself, because it will matter for the evidence ledger. He arrives at Horeb having asked to die, and he twice reports his situation in the same words: the people have forsaken the covenant, I alone am left, and they seek my life. The answer he receives is a correction of the count. Seven thousand have not bowed. The text preserves its hero's central self-assessment and then rejects it, which is not what a hagiography does.

4.5 THE ACTUATION STATED WHOLE

Strip the four acts to their common structure and the office appears. A man with no office, no salary, no guild, no patron, and no lineage claim, arraigns the holder of power in public, on a criterion announced in advance, in the domain the opposition claims as its own strength, and stakes his own standing on the result. He does not petition, does not lobby, does not accept an appointment, and does not found an institution. When the succession comes, it passes by a garment thrown over a man ploughing, not by ordination, election, or inheritance.

That is the mechanism, and it is repeatable, which is why it survived. What is transmitted is not a doctrine about rain, and not even primarily a doctrine about the single God, though the name carries one. It is a posture with an economic precondition, and Movement V takes up the precondition, because unfunded speech is not a virtue in this account. It is an instrument, and it has a cost.

Honest limit. None of this establishes that a man named Elijah lived in the ninth century. It establishes that a transmission with these properties existed, that its downstream is datable at multiple points across three corpora, and that its earliest named carrier is this one. The seat rests there and goes no further.

V. THE INSTRUMENTS

5.1 THE UNFUNDED CONDITION, READ AS AN INSTRUMENT RATHER THAN A VIRTUE

Movement II established the baseline: prophecy in this world was a palace function with a payroll, from the Mari āpilum filing reports with a hem and a lock of hair to the eight hundred and fifty at the queen's table. Against that baseline the sourcing of Ilyas AS is not incidental colour. It is the operative instrument, and the corpus is oddly specific about it.

At the Cherith wadi he is fed by ravens, and then the wadi dries because the drought he announced is general and does not exempt him. At Zarephath he is fed by a widow, and every term of that arrangement is structurally inverted from a payroll. She is a foreigner, a Sidonian, which places him inside the economic zone of the queen's own house and the Tyrian trade partner. She is a woman with no standing to grant patronage. She is at the end of her resources and says so, gathering sticks to cook a last meal for herself and her son before they die. And the sustenance is a jar of meal and a cruse of oil that do not empty, which read as economics rather than as wonder is a subsistence arrangement at the exact margin: he eats what a destitute household eats, daily, with no surplus, no store, and no contract.

The contrast is the point. Eight hundred and fifty prophets eat at a queen's table, which is a budget line. One eats at a foreign widow's, which is not. And the register's own operating law, that consensus and citation count carry zero evidential weight and that agreement among voices sharing one upstream source is one voice in costumes, has its narrative demonstration in 1 Kings 22: four hundred prophets, one payer, one answer, staged with iron horns, against a single dissenter the king says he hates because the dissenter never returns good news. The four hundred are counted once. That scene is the Hebrew corpus's own statement of why funding is the variable that matters, and it stands four chapters after Carmel.

5.2 TECHNIQUE

Four operational habits recur and each is a technique rather than a temperament.

The pre-registered criterion. At Carmel the test condition is stated once, publicly, before either attempt, and it is single. Nothing in the design permits post hoc reinterpretation, and the advantage of first attempt is conceded on the explicit ground of the opposition's numbers.

Direct address without intermediary. He does not petition through officials, does not seek audience, and does not use the messenger formulae of court correspondence. He appears, delivers, and leaves. The king's recognition line at the vineyard, have you found me, my enemy, is a description of the method.

Withdrawal between engagements. Cherith, Zarephath, the Negev, Horeb, and the repeated anxiety of Obadiah that the spirit will carry him off to somewhere unknown (1 Kings 18:12). This is read as flight, but structurally it is an operational pattern: he holds no fixed post that can be surrounded, no house that can be searched, and no property that can be attached. The absence of an address is part of the same instrument as the absence of a salary.

Succession by transfer rather than by institution. The mantle is thrown over a man at his plough. No ordination, no election, no lineage, no vote of the guild, and no royal confirmation.

5.3 THE SECOND CHAIR, WHICH THE REGISTER HAS NOT SEATED

Two carriers do the material work of this career and neither holds a seat.

Obadiah is *al ha-bayit*, over the house, the senior household office of the kingdom, an office attested in the region by seal impressions and inscriptions across the Iron Age Levant [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1 for the office, no attestation for this holder]. During the persecution he hid a hundred prophets in two caves, fifty in each, and supplied them with bread and water while continuing to run the king's establishment (1 Kings 18:4). That is the funding operation of the entire resistance, executed by a salaried royal official at mortal risk, and it is what made the guild survive to transmit anything. The corpus also preserves his fear, at length: he is afraid that if he reports the prophet's presence and the prophet then vanishes, the king will kill him (1 Kings 18:9-14). That fear is the cost of association, recorded from the associate's side.

The widow of Zarephath is unnamed, foreign, and destitute, and she carries the prophet through the drought years. The revival of her son is the first resurrection narrative in the Hebrew corpus and the account gives her the closing line rather than him: now I know that you are a man of God and that the word in your mouth is truth.

Under the register's Carrier Law, where the carrier is nameable the carrier is seated. Obadiah is nameable and unseated. That is recorded here as a sweep finding against the register itself, in the movement where it surfaced, rather than absorbed silently.

5.4 THE SUCCESSOR, AND THE ENROLMENT COST MADE EXPLICIT

Elisha AS is taken from twelve yoke of oxen, which is not a peasant holding; twelve pair working one field is a substantial estate and a labour force. He asks leave to kiss his father and mother, and then does something the narrative reports without comment and which is the whole of its meaning: he slaughters the yoke of oxen, burns the ploughing gear to cook the meat, feeds the people, and follows (1 Kings 19:19-21). He destroys his own means of return. The enrolment cost is paid in front of witnesses and made irreversible, and the text preserves it as the price of entry into an office with no salary attached.

His later request is stated in legal vocabulary that is usually lost in translation. A double portion of the spirit, *pi shnayim*, is the firstborn's inheritance share under Deuteronomy 21:17. He is not asking for twice the power. He is filing an inheritance claim on an estate whose only asset is an office, and the answer he receives makes the transfer conditional on witnessing the departure. The succession is framed throughout as a transfer of patrimony by a man who has no patrimony, which is the sharpest single expression of what the office is.

5.5 THE COST, STATED BECAUSE A COSTLESS READER WILL OTHERWISE MISS IT

The register's own audit law holds that a compiler without survival-coupling fails by blindness rather than by bias, and that the channel it most reliably closes is the one carrying what the work cost the subject. So the question is asked directly here rather than assumed.

The corpus preserves a collapse and does not soften it. After Carmel, under a death threat, he runs the length of the kingdom and then a further day into the wilderness, sits under a broom tree, and asks to die: it is enough, take my life, for I am no better than my fathers (1 Kings 19:4). He is then fed twice, in silence, before anything is asked of him. At Horeb he twice reports the same assessment, that he alone is left and they seek his life, and the answer corrects his count rather than praising his stand.

Around that sit the standing costs. Permanent itinerancy with no fixed residence. No wife, no children, and no household named anywhere in the cycle, in a culture where lineage is the ordinary form of continuity. No property, no office, no income, and no legal standing from which to be heard. And a public reputation as the cause of the disaster: the king's first words on meeting him are *ḡkēr yisrā ēl*, troubler of Israel, and the population living through a third year of failed rains had every reason to agree. Unfunded speech buys independence and pays for it in exposure, and the account preserves the invoice.

VI. CONTEST

The opposition is stated at its strongest, because a monograph that treats its subject's opponents as foils has already conceded the failure the register's domain guard exists to prevent.

6.1 AHAB, ON THE EVIDENCE RATHER THAN ON THE VERDICT

The Hebrew corpus renders a religious judgment on Ahab and it is severe. The external record renders a different kind of judgment and it is not.

At Qarqar in 853 BCE he fields two thousand chariots and ten thousand infantry in the coalition that meets Shalmaneser III, the largest chariot force in the alliance, larger than Damascus, in a campaign that checked the Assyrian advance for roughly a decade [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1]. His father's state is named after his house in Assyrian records for a century after the house is destroyed. His capital produced the ivory work that made the phrase "ivory house" literal, and his second centre at Jezreel is an excavated fortified complex. He held Moab as a tributary until his death, and Moab's own stele dates the revolt to after him.

The corpus's own account, read closely, is less flat than its reputation. He opens the Naboth transaction with a lawful offer and accepts refusal, going home sullen but empty-handed. He consults prophets before campaigning, including the dissenter he dislikes, and he goes into the battle the dissenter predicts he will lose. After the vineyard verdict he tears his clothes, fasts, and lies in sackcloth, and the text records that the sentence is deferred for it (1 Kings 21:27-29), a concession the redactors had no obligation to preserve.

Against all of this stands the fact that the account we have was compiled at least two centuries later by scribes of the rival southern kingdom, whose programme was that the north fell because of the cult this dynasty imported. Under the Provenance Firewall that is a compromised transmission on its face, and its agreement with the prophet it preserves is a reason for caution rather than confidence. A source is least reliable exactly where it most agrees with its editor.

6.2 JEZEBEL, STEELMANNED, AND WHERE THE STEELMAN STOPS

She is the most flattened figure in the cycle and the flattening is doing work, so the case for her is put fully.

A Tyrian royal woman married into a foreign house under a treaty maintains her ancestral cult because that is what a treaty marriage is. The arrangement is ordinary across the Near East, was ordinary in the Israelite court a century earlier under Sulayman AS 0123, and would have been unremarkable on the Tyrian side. Her patronage of prophets is state religious policy of a conventional kind and its scale is a measure of the crown's wealth rather than of her fanaticism. The register's own law, that motive and agenda flag a source and demote its tier but never force a verdict, applies to her as much as to anyone.

The sequence at Carmel deserves particular care because it is habitually read backwards. The killing at the Kishon comes before her threat, not after it. On the plain order of the text she responds to the execution of several hundred of her clergy with a death threat against the man who executed them, which is retaliation, and a state that did not retaliate for that would be remarkable. Readers who narrate the ordeal, skip the slaughter, and then present her threat as unprovoked malice have rearranged the evidence.

Where the steelman stops is Naboth, and it stops hard. There the record supplies not a religious dispute but a documented judicial murder, executed by written instruction under the royal seal, using the forms of law against a man whose only offence was declining a lawful offer, and terminating in the transfer of his land to the crown. The instrument is preserved in detail and the detail is the indictment. On Carmel the case is genuinely contested. On the vineyard it is not, and the distinction is kept sharp rather than blurred in either direction.

6.3 THE INSTITUTIONAL OPPOSITION, WHICH WAS NOT OBVIOUSLY INSINCERE

Zedekiah ben Chenaanah and the four hundred are usually read as cynics. The likelier reading is that they held the ordinary Near Eastern position: the national deity supports the national king's war, and a prophet's function is to confirm and to encourage. That was the professional consensus, it had ancient standing, and the register's own law zeroes it as warrant without thereby making its holders liars. Micaiah's dissent is presented in the text as unpopular, costly, and personally resented by the king, which is what dissent looks like inside a functioning institution rather than a corrupt one.

So the contest is institutional before it is moral. One side holds that prophecy is a service the crown funds and that its product is counsel. The other holds that prophecy is an arraignment the crown cannot fund and that its product is judgment. The second position has no economic base, which is exactly why it had to be unfunded, and exactly why it left no institution.

6.4 THE SCHOLARLY CONTEST

Two readings stand and neither can be closed on present evidence. The first holds that the Elijah and Elisha material preserves a northern prophetic narrative tradition of considerable antiquity, incorporated into the Deuteronomistic History from an older source [CONSENSUS-leaning; Tier 3]. The second holds that the cycle is substantially a late literary construction serving the Deuteronomistic programme, with no recoverable ninth-century core [DISPUTED; Tier 3]. What would decide it is an epigraphic or documentary witness naming the figure or the episodes, and none exists. The monograph's argument is deliberately built to survive either reading, since it is a claim about a transmission and its downstream rather than about a man and his deeds.

6.5 WHO BENEFITS, COMPACTLY

The Omride crown benefits from the Tyrian treaty in grain markets, craft imports, and Mediterranean access, and pays for it in a resident foreign cult. Tyre benefits in food security and a land corridor. The Israelite patrimonial smallholder is the party with no seat at that table, and the vineyard case is what it looks like when the crown's land appetite meets him. The Jerusalem temple establishment and the centralising monarchy of the late seventh century benefit, two hundred years later, from a northern precedent in which a prophet destroys a rival cult and indicts a king, and it is those beneficiaries who hold the pen when the cycle is finally written down. Each stage is a real interest and each shaped what survives.

VII. TRANSMISSION AT DEATH

The pivot of the monograph, and the movement an episode reconstruction does not have. At the moment the career stops, what existed, in what form, and in whose hands.

7.1 THERE IS NO DEATH, AND THE ABSENCE IS STRUCTURAL

Kings is a formulaic book. Every reign closes with a burial notice, a place, and a successor. Ilyas AS gets none of it. 2 Kings 2 gives a river parted by a struck mantle, a request framed as an inheritance claim, a separation by fire and whirlwind, and a garment falling to the ground. No body, no tomb, no burial formula, no site.

The structural consequence is large and it is the mechanism the whole transmission runs on. In the Iron Age Levant a tomb is a property claim and frequently a revenue centre; cults anchor to sites, sites generate custodians, custodians generate income, and income generates a lineage with an interest in controlling the memory. The patriarchal burial cave in Genesis is introduced with a full conveyance record, weighed silver and named witnesses, because a grave is real estate. Absent a body there is nothing to build on, nothing to charge admission to, and no family to inherit the custodianship. The memory therefore cannot be territorialised, and what cannot be territorialised travels.

The parallel is not accidental. Deuteronomy 34:6 states that no one knows the burial place of Musa AS to this day, and the same redactional tradition produced both notices. Two founding figures, two missing graves, in a corpus that otherwise records burial with care. Whether that is a theological principle, a polemic against

tomb cults, or an accident of transmission is not decidable here [DISPUTED; Tier 3], but its effect is not in doubt.

7.2 TESTIMONY AGAINST INTEREST, AND ONE CASE THAT FAILS THE GATES

The register's positive evidence channel holds that a document surviving against the interest of the class that transmitted it carries the highest weight that apparatus can generate, since transmitting classes control selection absolutely and unsupported material dies quietly by default. Four gates, conjunctive, defaults absent.

The search for the body. 2 Kings 2:16-18 preserves the guild insisting, over Elisha AS's refusal, on sending fifty men to search the hills for three days in case the spirit has set the body down somewhere, and failing to find him, and Elisha AS's I told you not to go. Gate one, the transmitting class and its stake: the prophetic guild and its redactors, whose authority in this very passage rests on the ascension and the legitimacy of the succession. Gate two, damage: the passage records that the eyewitness disciples did not find the ascension self-evident, conducted a search on the assumption of a body, and had to be told twice. Gate three, capacity to suppress: total, since the episode is dispensable and the narrative closes cleanly at verse 15. Gate four, compensating benefit: none apparent, since it makes the guild look faithless and the successor look overruled, and it supplies no polemical or apologetic advantage. Four gates pass. [AGAINST-INTEREST; Tier 1].

The collapse at Horeb. 1 Kings 19 preserves the hero asking to die, declaring himself no better than his fathers, and twice stating a self-assessment that the narrative then corrects with a headcount. Gate one, the prophetic tradition whose standing rests on him. Gate two, the damage is direct and unmitigated: the central figure is shown broken and factually wrong about the state of the resistance. Gate three, the whole Horeb sequence could have opened at the theophany. Gate four, no compensating benefit; the passage is not used to make a doctrinal point about humility anywhere in the corpus that preserves it. Four gates pass. [AGAINST-INTEREST; Tier 1].

The Naboth indictment, which fails. It is tempting to log the vineyard chapter the same way, since it indicts the elders and nobles, that is, the judicial and scribal class ancestral to the transmitters. Gate one passes, the class is nameable. Gate two passes, the damage is real. Gate three passes, the episode could have been told without the written instructions and the complying elders. Gate four fails. The elders in question are northern, and the Deuteronomistic programme is precisely the indictment of the northern establishment, so preserving their complicity carries a direct compensating benefit to the transmitting school. The gates bite, the case is refused, and the chapter is carried at ordinary Tier 3 with its detail noted rather than at the elevated grade. Recording the refusal is the discipline working; a channel that admitted everything attractive would not be an evidence channel.

7.3 THE CHANNEL DIFFERENTIAL

This is the codification seam's sharpest diagnostic: the same agent or milieu routes one body of speech to the pen and another away from it in the same period with the technology in daily use, and the differential is the signal rather than the content.

The technology was in daily use in the palace he confronted. The Samaria ostraca, some sixty-three inscribed sherds recording deliveries of oil and wine to the capital with regnal years, place names, and personal names,

come from the Samarian acropolis and date to the ninth or eighth century [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1]. Administrative literacy is sitting inside the building. Within roughly a century of his death, in his own kingdom, Amos and Hosea both leave collections under their own names, in their own voices, which are the two earliest such collections in the Hebrew corpus. So the format existed, the capacity existed, and the northern prophetic milieu adopted it within four generations.

And the greatest figure of that milieu leaves nothing. No oracle collection, no book, no attributed saying outside the narrative frame. Two readings account for it and neither excludes the other. The first is that his medium was act rather than oracle: he legislates nothing, and what he does is confront, which does not accumulate into a scroll the way an oracle series does. The second is that his transmission was designed to run through a person rather than a text, and the corpus says so directly, since the succession is a garment and an inheritance claim rather than an archive, and the successor's own cycle is likewise narrative and likewise leaves no collection. What is transmitted is a role, and roles are carried by people.

7.4 THE SEAM: DATE, PATRON, BENEFICIARY, COST

The material reaches us through a specific act of textualisation with a location and an interest.

The north fell in 722 BCE and its traditions moved south. The Deuteronomistic History was compiled in Jerusalem, its principal redaction in the late seventh century under the Josianic reform, with a further exilic revision [CONSENSUS; Tier 3]. The register seats that programme at Josiah 0157, "the Deuteronomic reform; centralization of cult as state policy." So the cycle is edited roughly two centuries after the events, in the rival kingdom, by a school whose thesis is that the northern kingdom fell because of the cult this prophet opposed.

Date, late seventh century with exilic revision. Patron, the Josianic court and its reform. Beneficiary class, the Jerusalem temple establishment and the centralising monarchy, for whom a northern prophet who annihilated a rival cult and arraigned a king is an ideal precedent, and who could deploy him without conceding anything to the north as a polity. Cost, and this is the part that cannot be recovered: whatever the northern tradition carried that did not serve that programme is gone, and there is no control text.

The expiry-against-fixation diagnostic reads cleanly here. His authority in life discharged on execution: he spoke, the thing happened or did not, and the authority was spent. Fixed in a text two centuries later, it becomes an authority that persists indefinitely and can be cited by anyone. That is the transition the seam names, and everything in Movement VIII is downstream of it.

The liability-authority coupling reads the same way. He holds no office and carries no institutional burden, so his authority was never coupled to a jurisdiction, a revenue, or a constituency. That uncoupling is the condition of his portability across three religions. It is also the condition of his appropriation, since an authority attached to no institution can be claimed by any institution that wants it, and several did.

The self-sawing gate, fired here and not after. The claim advanced in this movement is that the transmitting school was southern, interested, and editing a northern source. Can the corpus coherently testify to that? Testimony that one is an editor with a programme is coherent and does not destroy the transmission it edits; it is the ordinary condition of every historiographic source and the corpus's own superscriptions and regnal frameworks announce the editing openly. The gate passes and the verdict issues.

VIII. AFTERIMAGE

What he is credited with, set against what the record carries, with the difference fenced rather than narrated.

8.1 THE SENTENCE THAT MADE HIM PERMANENT

Malachi 3:23-24 in the Hebrew numbering, 4:5-6 in the Christian, is the most consequential sentence in the entire afterimage: a promise that Ilyas AS will be sent before the great and terrible day, to turn the hearts of fathers to children and children to fathers. It is dated c. 440 BCE and the register already seats it at Malachi AS 0222, "the last book of the prophetic canon; the messenger who prepares the way." The register held the slot without holding its occupant.

What that sentence does mechanically is convert an absence into an expectation. A prophet who died would be a closed file. A prophet with no grave, placed at the head of an eschatological sequence, becomes a permanently pending arrival, and a pending arrival is a slot that later traditions can fill, contest, and legislate around. Everything downstream in three religions is built on that conversion, and the conversion required the missing body established in Movement VII. The absence is load-bearing.

Ben Sira, c. 180 BCE, gives the first extended encomium at 48:1-11 and already treats him as a figure held in reserve for an appointed time [Tier 3]. The trajectory from narrative subject to standing office is complete within three centuries of the canon's close.

8.2 THE RABBINIC INSTALLATION, AND ITS INSTRUMENTS

The rabbinic tradition then installs the pending figure into recurring practice, and each installation has a mechanism worth naming rather than a sentiment.

Unresolved legal disputes are set aside with the term *teiku*, the matter stands, and the tradition glosses it as standing until Elijah AS comes and rules. That is a procedural device: an appeal court permanently in recess, which lets a legal system tolerate irreducible disagreement without either forcing a verdict or fracturing. A tradition that had buried its prophet could not have built it.

The cup poured and not drunk at the Passover table, the chair set for him at every circumcision, and the hymn at the close of the Sabbath install the same pending figure into the domestic and life-cycle calendar. These are post-canonical developments and under the Provenance Firewall they are witness-grade, carried with their provenance flag and never seal-eligible [Tier 4]. What they evidence is the shape of the afterimage, not the shape of the man.

8.3 THE CHRISTIAN APPROPRIATION, AND A CONTEST PRESERVED INSIDE IT

The Transfiguration places Musa AS and Ilyas AS beside ʿĪsā AS (Mark 9:2-8), the standard reading being Law and Prophets [CONSENSUS; Tier 3]. The forerunner slot is then applied directly: the Synoptic tradition identifies Yahya AS, John the Baptist, as the Elijah who was to come, with a conditional attached, if you are

willing to accept it (Matt 11:14, and Mark 9:11-13). The Fourth Gospel preserves the Baptist denying the identification outright when asked (John 1:21).

It is tempting to log that preserved denial under testimony against interest, since it damages a typology the transmitting church relied on. The gates refuse it. The transmitting community had a compensating benefit in preserving it, because the Fourth Gospel's programme systematically subordinates the Baptist to the one he announces, and a Baptist who declines every honorific serves that programme directly. Gate four fails and the passage is carried at ordinary tier. The refusal is recorded because a channel that admitted every attractive case would not be an evidence channel.

One reception detail is worth isolating because it is a clean, checkable instance of the afterimage overwriting the record. James 5:17-18 states that he prayed and it did not rain for three years and six months, and Luke 4:25 gives the same figure. 1 Kings gives no such number; it says the word came in the third year (1 Kings 18:1). The three-and-a-half years is a reception figure, carrying the apocalyptic half-week, and it entered general circulation and is now routinely cited as though it were in Kings. A number that is not in the source is the most traceable form of accretion there is, and it is logged here as such [DOCUMENTED; Tier 3, as a fact about the texts].

8.4 THE QURANIC REGISTER, AND WHAT SURVIVED THE CROSSING

Ilyas AS appears twice. Q 6:85 names him among the righteous alongside Zakariyya AS, Yahya AS, and 'Īsā AS. Q 37:123-132 gives the episode: he was among the messengers, he said to his people, will you not fear, do you call upon Ba'l and forsake the best of creators, they denied him, and the passage closes with peace upon Ilyāsīn.

Two observations carry real weight and are worth stating precisely.

First, the philological one. The closing form *Ilyāsīn* has been read as a variant of the name and, in a documented reading tradition, as *Āl Yāsīn*, the family of Yasin, and the variant is a genuine qirā'āt matter rather than a scribal curiosity [DISPUTED; Tier 3, warrant Type C with the reading-variant named as the premise].

Second, and more consequential, the Qurānic account preserves the single most historically specific element of the ninth-century cycle: the proper name of the rival god. Ba'l appears in this sense once in the entire Qurān, in this passage, attached to this prophet. A transmission that crossed roughly fifteen centuries, three language families, and at least two intermediate corpora carried forward not a moral, not a miracle, and not a chronology, but the name of the deity in the confrontation. That is a transmission fact of the first order and it is exactly what a Carried seat is for.

The corridor is nameable, which the register requires. The Elijah material reached the Hijaz through the Syriac Christian and Jewish communities of the northern Arabian and Levantine trade routes, a channel the register already seats at Ephrem the Syrian 0430 for the Syriac corpus and whose Arabian Jewish node the register carries in the Himyarite material at Dhu Nuwas 0403. Caravan and ecclesiastical routes, not ambient similarity.

The identification of Ilyas AS with al-Khiḍr, and the tradition of the four who remain living, are later developments outside the Qurānic text and are carried as reception at witness grade [DISPUTED; Tier 4], load-bearing on nothing here.

8.5 THE LARGEST GAP BETWEEN RECORD AND CREDIT

The Carmelite order supplies the sharpest case. Latin hermits settled on Mount Carmel in the late twelfth century and received a rule from Albert of Jerusalem c. 1206 to 1214; the order subsequently developed and defended an origin doctrine tracing its foundation to Ilyas AS himself and an unbroken succession on the mountain [DOC-FORMALIZED, dated instrument named; Tier 3]. The claim was contested at length in the seventeenth century in a formal literary dispute with the Bollandists and others [DOC-CONTESTED; Tier 3].

Set that against the record. There is no order, no rule, no habit, no property, no foundation, no school, no doctrine of the ascetic life, and no succession beyond a single named disciple. A thirteenth-century institution constructed a nine-hundred-year descent from a figure whose defining property was holding no institution at all. That inversion is the clearest illustration in the whole row of why the afterimage is fenced rather than narrated: the man's distinguishing feature was uninstitutionalisability, and the most durable thing built on him is an institution.

The site history closes it. A cave at the foot of Carmel above Haifa is venerated as his, concurrently, by Jewish, Christian, Muslim, and Druze communities, and shrines to al-Khaḍr across the Levant carry a fused identity in which Khiḍr, Ilyas AS, and Saint George are not cleanly separable [DOCUMENTED; Tier 2 for the practice]. The man with no grave acquired a cave, four custodies, and a merged identity. Nothing about that is evidence concerning the ninth century, and all of it is evidence concerning the transmission, which is what this seat records.

IX. THE DELETION TEST

Remove him from history. What fails to happen? The test runs in three parts and the register's Registration Law binds throughout: a seat is a claim about traceable actuation and surviving trace, never about worth, and a small answer stated plainly is worth more than a large one inflated.

9.1 SUBSTITUTION

High, and this must be conceded first because the honest answer is the useful one.

The destruction of the Tyrian Baal cult in Israel was carried out by an army coup, not by a prophet. Jehu's seizure of power is externally dated by the Black Obelisk of Shalmaneser III, which names Iaua mar Humri paying tribute, fixing the coup to 841 BCE [DOCUMENTED; Tier 1, seated at Shalmaneser III 0130]. And the Omride fall is over-determined by any reasonable causal accounting: sustained Aramean pressure from Damascus, Assyrian expansion, the Moabite revolt that Mesha 0132 records on his own stele, and a military coup with the officer corps behind it. Remove Ilyas AS entirely and the dynasty still falls on approximately that schedule, and the cult still goes with it.

Nor was he the only carrier of Yahwistic exclusivism. The Rechabites appear as an organised abstentionist lineage two centuries later claiming a founder from precisely this period (Jer 35), the nazirite institution

supplies another vector, and the Josianic reform is driven by a scroll and a king rather than by a prophet. The current had multiple channels.

9.2 DOWNSTREAM

Four things specifically fail, and they are all formal rather than eventual.

The Naboth template. Without that scene the Hebrew prophetic critique of expropriation has no founding case, and its later exponents demonstrably work from it. Amos on selling the needy for a pair of sandals, Isaiah AS on joining house to house until there is no room, and Micah on coveting fields and seizing them, houses and patrimonies, which reuses Naboth's own legal vocabulary. A tradition of prophetic economic critique that begins with a general denunciation rather than with a named king, a named smallholder, a named vineyard, and a documented judicial mechanism is a weaker instrument, because the specificity is what made it citable.

The forerunner slot. Malachi 3:23-24 requires a figure who did not die, and only this transmission supplied one at the right position in the canon. Without that slot the Synoptic openings have no grammar for the Baptist, the Transfiguration has no second figure beside Musa AS, and the entire announcement structure of the Gospel narrative has to be built from something else. This is the single largest downstream dependency in the row and it runs through an absence rather than a deed.

The Horeb relocation. The passage that empties wind, earthquake, and fire and locates the voice in a thin silence is the text three mystical traditions returned to for two millennia, and it is the hinge at which divine presence is decoupled from meteorological display inside a corpus surrounded by storm theology.

The office. Unfunded, unappointed, non-hereditary public arraignment of power on a stated criterion. Its clearest later occupant states it in the vocabulary of salary and guild, in the same kingdom, four generations on, when Amos denies being a prophet or a prophet's son and is told to go eat his bread elsewhere. The office is the thing that transmits, and it is the reason the seat exists.

9.3 RESIDUE

Small, and stated as small.

What is irreducibly this figure rather than the position he occupies? Very little at the level of deeds. Another man could have opened the office; the Naboth confrontation required a scene, not this scene; the forerunner slot required a figure without a grave, and the tradition supplied one. The events are substitutable and the record cannot even establish that they occurred.

What is not substitutable is a configuration, and it is a configuration of absences: no book, no patron, no grave. A prophet who left a collection is bounded by his own text and can be argued with on the page. A prophet with a patron is answerable to the payer and reads as such. A prophet with a tomb becomes a site, and a site becomes a custody, and a custody becomes a lineage with an interest in what he meant. This transmission escaped all three, and that is why a ninth-century Transjordanian confrontation is still supplying a legal-procedural device to one tradition, an announcement grammar to a second, and a named antagonist to a third fifteen centuries later in another language family.

The register is therefore seating a shape rather than a man, and the Carried grade says exactly that on its face. It is the honest form of the finding and it is not a diminished one.

9.4 THE CLOSE

Three axes stand. What stands is a man of no office, no lineage claim, and no property, arriving from the periphery into a court at the height of its international success. What moves is a strike aimed at a specialist's competence in his own domain, an ordeal designed on a criterion announced in advance and conceded advantage, an arraignment of a reigning king over a commoner's patrimony, and the emptying of the storm-god's manifestation vocabulary at a mountain. How the two bind is an office: unfunded public arraignment, transmitted by a garment to a successor and by an absence to a canon.

The three do not collapse into one another and the composition lands. The reading closes at its stated grade, which is structural on the office and its transmission, conditional on the ninth-century core, and premise-grade nowhere except where the corpus's own claims are carried as its claims.

⌞ GOL

BOX 1 | EVIDENCE LEDGER WITH FALSIFIERS

Every load-bearing claim, its tier, its label, and what would overturn it.

The Omride state was militarily and diplomatically first-rank. Tier 1, [DOCUMENTED]. Kurkh Monolith chariot count, Mesha Stele, Bit-Humri in Assyrian records, Samaria and Jezreel excavations. Falsifier: redating of the Kurkh Monolith or of the Samaria stratigraphy that removes the Omrides from the mid-ninth century.

Baal arrived in Samaria by a Tyrian treaty marriage on a documented commercial corridor. Tier 3 for the marriage, Tier 1 for the corridor economics. [CONSENSUS]. Falsifier: evidence that the Samaritan Baal cult predates the Omride period in the capital, which would make the marriage incidental rather than causal.

Rain was Baal's defining competence, making the drought a targeted strike. Tier 1 on the theology, from the Ugaritic corpus. [DOCUMENTED]. Falsifier: none plausible on the theology; the inference to targeting is Tier 3 and would fall if the drought narrative were shown to be a late addition to the cycle independent of the Baal frame.

Prophecy in this milieu was predominantly a salaried palace function. Tier 1 from Mari, Tier 3 from Kings. [DOCUMENTED]. Falsifier: documentary evidence of widespread independent unsalaried prophetic activity in the Iron Age Levant, which no archive currently shows.

No oracle collection stands under his name, while Amos and Hosea produce collections in the same kingdom within a century. Tier 1 as a fact about the corpus. [DOCUMENTED]. Falsifier: recovery of a collection.

Administrative literacy was present in the Samaritan palace in or near his generation. Tier 1, Samaria ostraca. [DOCUMENTED]. Falsifier: redating of the ostraca to the late eighth century only, which would weaken but not remove the channel-differential argument, since Amos and Hosea still stand.

The cycle reaches us through a late-seventh-century Jerusalem redaction with a programmatic interest. Tier 3, [CONSENSUS]. Falsifier: a pre-722 northern manuscript witness, which would transform the transmission question entirely.

The guild's three-day search for the body is testimony against interest. Tier 1 in the evidentiary sense, [AGAINST-INTEREST]. Four gates pass. Falsifier: demonstration of a compensating benefit to the transmitting school in preserving the disciples' doubt, which would fail gate four as the Naboth case and the Baptist denial already do.

Malachi 3:23-24 converts the missing body into a standing eschatological office. Tier 3 as a textual fact, [DOCUMENTED]. Falsifier: none; the sentence is in the text and dated.

The three-and-a-half year drought figure is reception, not record. Tier 3, [DOCUMENTED] as a fact about the texts. Falsifier: a Kings textual witness carrying the figure.

The Carmelite descent claim is a thirteenth-century construction. Tier 3, [DOCUMENTED]. Falsifier: pre-medieval evidence of a continuous eremitical community on Carmel claiming this founder.

That a man named Elijah lived in the ninth century. Tier 3, [UNVERIFIED], carried as the tradition's claim and never upgraded. Falsifier or verifier: an epigraphic or documentary witness. None exists.

BOX 2 | SUMMARY MATRIX

Window. c. 870 to 850 BCE traditional, anchored to Ahab, whose absolute date is fixed at 853 BCE from outside the Hebrew corpus.

Locale. Gilead in Transjordan as origin; Samaria, Jezreel, and Carmel as theatre; Zarephath in Phoenicia and Horeb in the far south as withdrawal.

Actors. Ilyas AS; Ahab 0129; Jezebel of Tyre; Obadiah the royal steward, unseated; the widow of Zarephath, unnamed; Elisha AS the successor, unseated; Naboth of Jezreel; the prophetic guild; the eight hundred and fifty court prophets.

Anchor snippet. No dew and no rain these years except by my word (1 Kings 17:1). Have you found me, my enemy (1 Kings 21:20). Do you call upon Baʿl and forsake the best of creators (Q 37:125).

Corroboration keys. Kurkh Monolith 853 BCE; Mesha Stele c. 840 BCE; Black Obelisk 841 BCE; Samaria ostraca; Samaria ivories; Ugaritic Baal Cycle KTU 1.1 to 1.6; Menander of Ephesus via Josephus at Tier 4.

Actuation. The office of unfunded public arraignment, transmitted by mantle rather than by scroll, and made permanent by the conversion of a missing body into a standing eschatological slot.

Doctrinal stakes. Yahwistic cultic exclusivism against a treaty-borne rival cult; patrimonial land tenure against royal expropriation; the decoupling of divine presence from storm manifestation; and, downstream, the forerunner slot on which the Gospel announcement structure is built.

Confidence. Documented on the milieu and the downstream. Tier 3 and unverified on the person. The seat is Carried and the aperture is at the upstream, where it belongs.

BOX 3 | METHOD, EXTERNAL DIFF, AND SWEEP

External corpora diffed, as the audit law requires, since this instrument cannot audit itself and its characteristic failure is a channel that closes without a signal. Noth's formulation of the Deuteronomistic History supplies the redactional frame used in Movement VII. Cross and Mark Smith supply the Baal and Yahweh polemical reading applied in Movements II and IV. Finkelstein and Silberman supply the Omride rehabilitation that Movement VI runs on, and Rofé supplies the genre analysis of the prophetic legend that Movement VI's second scholarly position represents.

Where this reading departs. The standard treatments read the cycle either for its theology, the emergence of exclusive Yahwism, or for its literary history, source and redaction. This reading brackets both and reads the economics of the office instead: who paid, who did not, and what the difference made to what survived. From Finkelstein it takes the Omride rehabilitation and departs on the prophetic material, since the argument here is deliberately built to survive both an early-core and a late-construction verdict, being a claim about a transmission rather than about a man. From Cross and Smith it takes the structural anti-Baal reading and departs by refusing to let the theophany carry any verdict, which is the domain guard operating.

Axis swept. The second chair and the funder. Obadiah, holder of the senior household office of the kingdom, who financed and hid the entire surviving prophetic guild at mortal risk, is nameable and holds no seat in the register. The widow of Zarephath and Elisha AS are likewise carriers without seats, the latter Qur'anically named at Q 6:86 and Q 38:48. Recorded as findings against the register rather than absorbed silently.

Cost-blindness check. Run in Movement 5.5 rather than assumed. The corpus preserves a collapse, a death wish, permanent itinerancy, no household, and a public reputation as the author of the famine. The instrument reached that answer from the text rather than supplying it from expectation.

Domain guard. This monograph reads transmission architecture, conduct, and record. It issues no verdict on whether any event occurred, on whether the theophany was what the corpus says it was, or on the truth of any doctrine traced. The interior of the subject routes to the apophatic register and stays premise-grade permanently.